

Checklist for open source career aspirants

Here is a quick checklist of the skillsets companies using open source seek in the freshers and experienced people they hire.

Fresher requirements

- Problem solving skills
- Willingness to learn and explore continuously
- Passion and belief in open source
- Project experience, seminar exposure, etc

Skills wanted in experienced people

- An understanding of the overall architecture of the tool stack
- Strong basics and an aptitude for learning
- Well networked with the community
- A strong knowledge about licensing
- The capability to explore and provide solutions
- Participation in the open source community (not necessarily professional participation)

have grown beyond their initial popularity among hackers and are today being adopted by enterprises across the globe. There is as much, if not more, demand for open source enterprise products as for their proprietary counterparts. Thus, the biggest driving force for the escalating demand for Linux/FOSS professionals is the mass movement of enterprise software companies towards open source," says Aravind Kumar, chief technology officer, Agriya Infoway, with about 75-100 FOSS/Linux experts.

"Open source applications are now available for every type of enterprise software. The code base is stable, increasing the reliability of the software. Altogether, open source software provides better value, lower costs, and improved security, addressing all enterprise considerations today. The currently available technically trained workforce meets only one-third of the demand for Linux professionals; thus, the future is bright for open source enthusiasts," adds

Aniruddha Banerjee, head, technology services business, Sonata Software.

Miscellaneous forces at work

Alongside these trends, cloud computing, e-governance, Web 2.0 technologies, maturity of open source tools themselves, and the speed at which they keep up with new application technology, are crucial factors resulting in demand for FOSS/Linux experts. On one hand, there is no application as scalable as a cloud using open source, while on the other, the government is driving the demand for FOSS experts. "We see a huge demand from state governments in India like Andhra Pradesh and Karnataka, and European states like France. Thus, the time is ripe for FOSS/Linux experts to grow and blossom in the Indian market," says Kumar.

Further, strong support for FOSS/Linux from commercial vendors – for instance, Java and MySQL supported by Oracle; PHP by Zend; Python by Google; and Eclipse by IBM – is also driving the demand for FOSS/Linux experts. "Web 2.0 technologies are also driving demand for these experts as more than 50 per cent of Web 2.0 solutions built today are coming from open source tools. PHP, Ruby on Rails and Python have reached the right maturity levels to build high traffic consumer and enterprise applications," says Gokul Muralidharan, open source expert, Aspire Systems, a company with about 140 developers involved in open source software development.

Put your career on the fast-growth track

But, a growing market alone isn't alluring enough for developers. Abraham Lincoln had once said: "I don't think much of a man who is not wiser today than he was yesterday." Developers bitten by the technology bug would nod in agreement. They need much more than a big fat salary and a secure job. Does open source offer them that? Most definitely so!

A whole range of toys to play with

Passionate developers can never get enough of technology. They always want more and that is exactly



"From developing new products using FOSS and implementing enterprise solutions, to integrating open source modules with existing commercial blocks – there are a whole gamut of opportunities for FOSS and Linux experts."

Deepak Gupta, associate vice president, technology, GlobalLogic